



THE QUIET TYPE

Kayani (right) is a non-controversial figure for most Pakistani parties and is committed to a policy of not making statements on matters outside the army

smoker and a keen golfer, he usually keeps his views to himself. "He is an extremely good listener," says a journalist who has attended briefings given by Kayani. "He keeps jotting things down on a pad he carries with him and speaks very little."

It is also quite obvious that Kayani enjoys the support of the Americans. The general is a graduate of the Command and General Staff College at Fort Leavenworth, Kansas and his work as ISI chief put him in constant touch with his counterparts in the US military establishment. The Pentagon obviously is confident that it knows him fairly well. When US Deputy Secretary of State John Negroponte visited Pakistan two weeks ago, he met Musharraf once but Kayani, then still vice-chief, twice. Kayani's first task as head of the army may be to stamp his own authority on it and to rebuild its sagging morale, pulled down by rising extremist violence and popular opposition to military rule. He will also have to balance the imperatives of Pakistan's alliance with the US against his countrymen's disaffection

with it. Kayani is the first army chief since 1969 to continue to serve under his old boss—Generals Musa Khan and Yahya Khan had served under 'Field Marshal' Ayub Khan during the latter's rule from 1958-69. But loyalties to benefactors aside, Pakistani history has shown that an army chief is often his own man. Many see Kayani as a tougher version of Jahangir Karamat—the former army chief forced to resign by prime minister Nawaz Sharif in 1998—who also carried the reputation of having a sound intellectual base, as well as being a gentleman soldier.

In the rough and tumble of Pakistani politics, where the army chief becomes the centre of gravity for all the wrong reasons, General Kayani may need all the toughness he can muster to resist the temptations that will inevitably come his way.

by Hasan Zakki

The US is confident that it knows the new army chief well.

and instead helped the entire Sharif family return in a royal aircraft to a riotous welcome back home in Lahore. Even as Sharifs' return energised the opposition to Musharraf, the threat of a poll boycott by the combined opposition continued to confuse the general public. Instability looms over Pakistan amid questions about Musharraf's own future.

As a former commander, Musharraf is used to acting by the seat of his pants. It is said that his eyes are fixed firmly only on the immediate future—the general elections due on January 8. Not only would he like to ensure that the polls are credible enough—by heading off large-scale boycott—but also make as certain as possible an elected set-up that does not pose a threat to him.

For now he seems to be succeeding at least on some fronts. After an initial bout of fiery rhetoric, Pakistan People's Party (PPP) chief Benazir Bhutto seems to have toned down the tenor of